

ARE ALL CASES TREATED EQUAL?: USING GOFFMAN'S FRAME ANALYSIS TO UNDERSTAND HOW HOMICIDE DETECTIVES ORIENT TO THEIR WORK

SHILA R. HAWK and DEAN A. DABNEY*

Drawing upon ethnographic data from one US metropolitan police department's homicide unit, this study employs Goffman's frame analysis to explore two questions: (1) What types of cases are prioritized in homicide investigations? and (2) How are those prioritizations operationalized and justified? Themes within the data suggest that although detectives struggle to 'work every case the same', their approach and effort on cases is nonetheless influenced largely by unit culture and perceptions of victim deservedness. Furthermore, we demonstrate that framing techniques enable investigators to compartmentalize and manage the emotional strain of deprioritizing some homicides while rigorously investigating other cases. These findings add to our understanding of the administration of homicide work, theorize the moral complexities of said work and point to frame analysis as a potentially useful framework for crime researchers.

Keywords: frame analysis, homicide investigation, victim deservedness, police culture

Introduction

In the United States, murder investigation occupies a prominent role in both the public's field of vision specific to the crime problem and law enforcement's crime fighting apparatus; popular media portrayals, ranging from the evening news to televised docudramas focus public interest on homicide work, whilst police command staff prioritize homicide clearance over nearly all forms of crime. Although murder investigations draw considerable attention from a wide array of constituents, there exists a paucity of research on homicide work. Faced with complex criminal investigations, homicide detectives must sort out complex crime scenes along with multifaceted relationships and moral identities between participants, all whilst holding their emotions in check (Stenross and Kleinman 1989; Pogrebin and Poole 1991; Innes 2002a). Given the complexity of the enterprise, detectives create and perpetuate case typologies to facilitate their work. How cases are described and classified by detectives can be important determinants of the work that gets done and conclusions that follow (Innes 2003). The behaviours and cognitive schema of homicide investigators are arguably important, but largely overlooked predictors of case processes and outcomes (Wellford and Cronin 1999; Keel *et al.* 2009). Fully appreciating the lived experience of US homicide work can provide a more holistic understanding how the social construction of justice is realized.

Research suggests that the emotional labour associated with their everyday interactions lead police officers to develop predictable 'work personalities' marked by feelings of social isolation, suspicion, cynicism and conservatism (Stenross and Kleinman 1989;

*Shila R. Hawk and Dean A. Dabney, Department of Criminal Justice and Criminology, Georgia State University, 140 Decatur Street, 1201 Urban Life Building, Atlanta, GA 30303, USA; ddabney@gsu.edu.

Innes 2002b). Pogrebin and Poole (1991) assert that officers use cognitive schemas to mentally distance themselves during tragic human events. These schemas are shaped by the work environment, and likewise shape the behaviours and thought processes of the officers. For example, Pogrebin and Poole (1988) and Vivona (2014) note the importance of socialized work humour as a means of defusing stress, normalizing crises and building solidarity amongst homicide investigators.

Although some aspects of the police officer working personality may be stable across rank and/or units, homicide detectives face unique types and levels of stress, responsibility, scrutiny, fatigue, gore, prestige and urgency associated with their jobs (Dabney *et al.* 2013). Similarly, although experiencing careers that move them throughout the police bureaucracy, working within a homicide unit fosters a unique approach and disposition to policing (Innes 2003). Differences in work roles and cultural contexts likely lead homicide investigators to develop distinctly situated work personalities. It is within this context that the current framing of homicide, including the typification of cases, offenders and victims, is perpetuated.

The present study deconstructs the framing of homicide investigations, focusing specifically on the typification of homicide victims and cases. Building on the premise that agents of the criminal justice system use perceptual frames to manage actions and emotions within their work world (Sudnow 1965; Waegel 1981), we explore the degree to which homicide investigators invoke a sense of victim deservedness to shape the way investigators prioritize and work cases. Although it seems logical that the daily work processes and orientations of the detectives that investigate the cases shape the homicide clearance outcomes, there currently exists very little systematic research on investigator and unit-level measures and how they relate to case outcomes (Roberts 2007; Xu 2008). By focusing attention on several aspects of unit culture, we hope to stimulate further thought and empirical inquiry into the relationship between these local-level factors and homicide-case outcomes.

We employ Goffman's (1974) 'frame analysis' approach to theorize the ways in which investigators make sense of their work. In this regard, the following two research questions guide this inquiry: (1) What types of cases are prioritized in homicide investigations and (2) What sorts of frames do homicide investigators use to construct and justify those prioritizations?

The culture of homicide work

Previous research has shown that high levels of stress, centralized working quarters and relatively low levels of unit turnover make for a tight-knit organizational culture within a given homicide unit (Innes 2010; Dabney *et al.* 2013). This culture is maintained through storytelling, unit traditions and shared experiences (Innes 2002a). There are also characteristics unique to the nature of work in a homicide unit; unlike with other crimes, homicide investigators maintain primary responsibility over their cases from their arrival on the crime scene through its final disposition. As such, they become more familiar with and invested in their cases; they tend to learn more about the backgrounds and lifestyles of their victims, witnesses and suspects than most any other type of criminal investigator. It stands to reason that the depth and longevity of case involvement nurtured within a close-unit culture will yield collective work-related behaviours and cognitive schema.

Although the American media and public have a tendency to glamourize the nature of criminal investigation work, the daily routine of a detective is generally mundane and repetitious (Sanders 1977). The repetition in general case characteristics and investigative techniques yield common expectations, stereotypes and world views, both within and across unit members. When the identity of the offender is not readily apparent from the crime scene (i.e. offender has fled the scene or there is a scarcity of witnesses or physical evidence), homicide detectives are trained to construct a victimology to operationalize the background and final movements of the decedent. Seeing similar victim profiles over and over again, it becomes natural to form typifications in this regard. Case studies reveal that homicide units are vulnerable to typifications such as the 'true victim', 'dead dope boy'¹ and 'thug'² (Simon 1999). The repeated manifestation of these schema and typifications may impact the efficiency and effectiveness of investigation.

Victim deservedness

Typifications can arise out of the perceived level of victim participation in crimes and is noted to be an important issue in police discretion (Klinger 1997). Scholars posit that victims are not always just 'passive recipients' of offender attention but rather 'complementary partners' in the murder transaction (Wolfgang 1972; Luckenbill 1977). It is understood that risk of victimization is heightened when people are in vulnerable situations, associate with criminals or are offenders themselves (Lauritsen *et al.* 1991). Victim precipitation is a perceived behaviour, feature or adjustment of a victim that triggers the actions of the offender (Amir 1967). This implies that victimization is patterned socially, spatially and temporally based upon personal, physical and/or situational factors that serve as an invitation for confrontation. Similar judgements may cause police to 'view victims of crimes in certain situations as more or less deserving of police attention' (Bynum *et al.* 1982: 303).

Christie (1986) goes further to differentiate between 'ideal victims' and 'non-ideal victims'. He argues that demographics, lifestyle and event dynamics elicit public perceptions and reactions to persons who fall prey to serious crime. Specifically, he defines an 'ideal victim' as 'a person or a category of individuals who – when hit by crime – most readily are given the complete and legitimate status of being a victim' (Christie 1986: 18). In a broad sense, macro-level factors such as race, age, socio-economic status and gender shape these perceptions, as poor, disadvantaged young men are more likely to be framed as non-ideal victims that contribute to their own demise by virtue of their at-risk lifestyles, whilst wealthy, white, middle-aged women are likely to be afforded the ideal victim designation due to social identities assigned to this demographic group. At the micro-level, Christie theorizes that assessments are made on a case-by-case basis based upon the individual-level characteristics at hand. He identifies six micro- and macro-level factors that shape an 'ideal victim' status at the micro-level: (1) being weak; (2) being involved in a respectable project when victimized; (3) being in a respectable

¹ A dope boy is a term used by American police to refer to anyone who sells and/or distributes drugs.

² A thug is a term used by American police to refer to someone who is habitually violent, hardened, cruel, tough, and/or criminal.

or safe setting; (4) being attacked by a big and bad offender; (5) being attacked by a stranger and (6) being ascribed a victim status by members of the community (Christie 1986). A relevant question remains whether or not law enforcement agents share similar victim typifications. Pogrebin *et al.* (1986) found that detectives use symbolic clues, such as neighbourhood context and personal items, to judge a dead person's social identity and worth. Thus, if detectives feel victims did not do enough to protect themselves, they are unlikely to view them as a 'true victim' or feel that their investigative efforts are worthwhile (Stenross and Kleinman 1989).

It is suggested that when police officers view victims as active participants, they are less inclined to aggressively advocate for the victim (Bynum *et al.* 1982). Research suggests judgements about victims' moral worth, social context, culpability and demographics play a role in policing decisions. For instance, stereotypes and where the victim lived have been shown to affect police decision-making and perceptions of victim worthiness (Sobol 2010). Specifically, Correia *et al.* (2002: 338) found that 'the innocent victim was judged more attractive, less devalued, more behaviourally responsible, was considered more deserving and in a more just situation than a non-innocent victim'. This study adds to the research on victim deservedness by examining how homicide investigators typify victims and subsequently prioritize their cases.

Theoretical framework

Goffman (1974) conceived frame analysis as a heuristic tool to deconstruct the cognitive processes and schema that individuals enlist when they are not able to handle all the situational realities they face at any given time. He saw people as active social agents that construct and draw upon cognitive laminates to compartmentalize overwhelming or problematic information; they reflect on themselves and are capable of shaping their actions and interactions to conform to the norms and values of their social world (Ritzer 2008). That is, people act based on how they frame what they have learnt through interpretations of others' reactions to them. Behaviour is different from action; the former being a 'mechanical response to stimuli' and the latter an 'active, creative, mental process' (Ritzer 2008: 463). Depending on the situation, we frame things to focus on the information relevant for action in specific circumstances. In this regard, Goffman would posit that homicide investigators use frames to organize their work role behaviours and actions into manageably relevant 'strips' of information, such as delivering a death notification, interrogating a suspect and conducting neighbourhood canvases. Each of these cue different cognitive references for a detective to know how to act appropriately.

Goffman (1974) outlined five domains that people use to compartmentalize or frame information about which they think and act. The most fundamental frame is the main frame, which reveals that which is perceived as *really* happening in the social world. The main frame is the ideology that someone uses to shape the dominate imagery. The meaning of a main frame can be challenged in various ways, causing it to become keyed or redefined. This occurs when its meaning is transformed into something patterned on but independent of the main frame; Goffman deemed the resulting manifestations 'ancillary' frames. Every keying can itself be rekeyed within four other types of ancillary frames: the directional, concealment, overlay or disattend frames. The directional

frame helps someone to focus on important information, whilst disregarding other factors; things are perceived but ignored. The concealment frame consists of information that should be known but is completely hidden. The overlay frame allows someone to routinize information in an impersonal manner, so some information does not affect a narrative. Finally, the disattend frame includes fabrications of information. Any of these frames can be combined to fit the compartmentalization needed for action.

Although frame analysis grew out of the sociological tradition, to date most of its application has been realized within other disciplines. It has been used by political science scholars to explain campaign phenomena (Morreal 1991) and social movements (Benford and Snow 2000), communications scholars articulate to media presentations on various topics (Semetko and Valkenburg 2000) and by education researchers to shed light on pedagogical and education policy topics. The use of frame analysis to study issues germane to sociologists and criminologists has been limited (Young 2010). Levi's 1981 work focusing on how hitmen frame their internal and external presentations of self stands as a rare exception. Drawing upon a case-study approach, Levi (1981) operationalized the frames a contract killer as they apply to what he deemed neutralizations in a very deviant career. Similarly, we use it to examine how homicide investigators use frames to define and prioritize their cases. In particular, the current study draws attention to a disconnect between the subjective application of extralegal factors, such as the role of the victim, and the objective goal of solving murder cases. Disentangling the overlapping cognitive structures that detectives draw upon and utilize daily will increase understanding of police impression management, the investigative process and ultimately case outcomes.

Methods

This study employs an inductive approach to examining American homicide detectives' case orientation and resulting investigative efforts. Ethnographic data, derived from participant observations and semi-structured interviews, were collected from one large metropolitan police department's homicide unit located in the Southeast region of the country. The department is staffed by roughly 2,000 sworn officers with jurisdiction over approximately 150 square miles and experiences an average of 100 homicides a year. Over the past decade, the department's annual clearance rate for these cases had ranged between 70 and 85 per cent. At the time of data collection, the 26-member homicide unit was made up of mostly males, with varied ages and mixed on-the-job experience, diverse ethnicities and different ranks. Roughly two-thirds of the staff members were investigators assigned to cases on a unit-rotation basis. Heavy caseloads are the norm, with each investigator shouldering lead responsibility for 5–10 cases annually. The unit is partitioned into two shifts: day and evening watch. When a homicide occurs, all members of the shift, a team of civilian crime scene technicians and a medical examiner respond to the call to assist the lead detective with evidence collection.

Once the crime scene is fully processed, the lead detective assumes primary responsibility for processing evidence, identifying suspects, consulting with prosecutors, clearing the case and assembling a case file documenting all aspects of the investigation. Unit supervisors conduct periodic case file reviews and allocate additional resources as deemed necessary during the follow-up investigation. Where arrests occur, the case file

is turned over to a county prosecutor for adjudication consideration. At this point, the prosecutor's office assumes a primary role, levying charges and deciding on an appropriate disposition strategy. Most arrests result in a felony trial or plea bargain with all officers who were involved in the case routinely being subpoenaed to testify in pre-trial and trial activities that occur before a felony court judge and/or jury.

Prior to the onset of data collection efforts, the full unit staff was briefed on the research project and each given an informed consent form clearly stating their participation was voluntary and identities would be kept anonymous. All 26 members of the unit chose to participate fully. Data collection occurred over a 9-month period in 2009 and 2010. Approximately, 300 hours of fieldwork occurred through ride-a-longs, Compstat meetings,³ crime scene processing and other day-to-day operations. Field notes were taken during all observation sessions. A semi-structured interview was woven into each ride-a-long session. Protocol-guided, conversational-style interviews yielded 2–3 hours of additional data. Content areas included detective's work history, perceptions of the homicide investigator's role and various forms of occupational, organizational and personal stressors present in homicide work. There was no expectation that the topics would be covered in order or during one sitting, yet each officer was queried on all the topics during the interview. Interviews and field notes were electronically recorded and transcribed. The NVivo software was used to organize a coding and analysis protocol that relied on thematic content analysis and the constant comparative method (Berg 2007). Initial coding passes relied upon the topical headings of the interview guide to generate generic themes in the data. Subsequent passes partitioned the data using the conceptual categories germane to case typification and as well as the precepts of frame analysis.

Findings

What types of cases are prioritized in homicide investigations?

Homicide detectives respond to any call for service involving a dead body with suspicion of foul play.⁴ Predictable access to a victim provokes a heavy emphasis on victimology. From the outset of an investigation, detectives seek to understand the victim's lifestyle, recent movements and acquaintances. For the homicide investigator, everything works backwards from the victim (Cronin *et al.* 2007); this includes recreating the lethal transaction, identifying the parties to the criminal event (witnesses, involved parties and suspects) and discerning the motivational and behavioural factors of the crime. The data suggest an almost immediate and predictable effort to typify the victim. Asked about case clearances, Investigator-2 said:

The victim type definitely factors into it. You've got a homeless guy with no family, no connexion, no solid point to work what we call a victimology on him, to find out his likes, dislikes, who he ran with;

³ Compstat is an organizational approach to policing that heavily relies on crime data and weekly analyses-driven meetings used to progressively manage departments by focusing on goal and objective setting, collaboration, accountability and planning (Dabney 2010).

⁴ Homicide investigators in the department under study were also dispatched to scenes where a victim was severely injured and transported to the hospital with slim odds of survival. Although the victim was not physically present upon their arrival, they would have a known victim as a starting point.

that's going to be a difficult case to solve, because you don't know why he was where he was or what he was doing, or why. So victim type does factor into the solvability of a case.

The data strongly suggest that victim deservedness or victim precipitation lies at the core of victim typification and the case prioritization that follows. Prominent in this regard were investigators' use of a 'true victim' designation. This term closely approximates Christie's (1986) use of the term 'ideal victim'. Background factors such as race, gender and socio-economic status appear to play a predictable role in this assessment, with certain demographic groups being afforded a privileged status, whilst others are judged more sceptically than others. Given that homicide victims are not alive to describe what happened and investigators often arrive on scene with no witness present or much strong physical evidence to work with, it is understandable that personal background characteristics come to play a large role in the investigators' typification process. Children, elderly people and fellow law enforcement officers were consistently assigned 'true victim' status. Investigator-19 justified this as follows:

Young children, the elderly and police officers are always gonna be the three that evoke the most emotion . . . One, you've got defenceless victims when you have elderly or children. And, two, you also don't have as many of them . . . Our victims are 16 to 25 . . . gotta be the 80 % of our victims. So when we see something that's different than that, it is different.

As Christie (1986) and Pogrebin *et al.* (1986) have theorized, our data indicated that investigator typifications of the 'true victim' were shaped by what is known about the moments preceding death. These constitute important foreground factors that, when blended with personal background factors, shape the detectives' assessment of victim deservedness. Describing the foreground behavioural dimension of the 'true victim' type, Investigator-26 noted:

Their behaviour did not lead to their demise. They were minding their own business; not bothering anybody, just living their own life and they were victimised. And that would be considered a 'true victim'. They weren't engaged in any kind of illegal activity that would warrant someone coming after them.

These undeserving victims display characteristics such as being weak/vulnerable, involved in respectable behaviours and/or located in a safe setting. A host of terms were used by investigators to capture the ideal type of a 'true victim', 'good victim', 'victim victim', 'real victim' and 'solid citizen'. Regardless of the term, the follow-up narrative consistently highlighted what Christie deemed necessary foreground and background conditions of 'ideal victim' status. For example, Investigator-23 described a 'true victim' as:

someone who was minding their own business, not committing a crime, not committing a misdemeanour, not committing a felony, they just happened to be in the wrong place at the wrong time . . . that is what we call a 'true victim' . . . It's just different because you know you have someone that shouldn't have been killed.

Christie (1986) used the term 'non-ideal victim' for those who do not command the same level of sympathy and humanistic response. As noted above, 'true victim' cases were deemed atypical for the homicide detectives that were interviewed. Most murder victims in the jurisdiction under study were able-bodied men who, at

the time of death, were involved in criminal acts in dangerous locales. Detectives consistently describe victims as 'put[ting] themselves in the position to be killed' (Investigator-15). Similarly, Investigator-16 said, 'Let's face it, a lot of times we don't have 'true victims' here. You know, you're out dealing drugs or you're out trying to do something [criminal] and something bad happens to you'. The concept of victim precipitation was commonly applicable in this regard where personal background factors and situational foreground factors suggested that the person either contributed to or could have averted the deadly outcome through a meaningful self-defence.

Detectives consistently described a collective, unit-wide sentiment toward the 'true victim' category; investigators routinely noted, 'everybody steps up' when the case involves infants, the elderly and law enforcement officers and the behavioural factors detailed above. These are demographic background factors commonly associated with 'true victims'. That said, there was evidence that unit norms recognized certain foreground factors such as a person slain whilst going about law-abiding activities or who did not contribute to his/her own demise. The heightened emotion and affront clearly inspires vigorous engagement from individual detectives, the homicide unit as a whole and the entire police force. As Investigator-11 explained, 'I see more of a team effort come into play once it's an innocent victim being worked verses the ghetto murder . . . you have a team effort working that innocent victim [case] . . . because the whole unit is just bothered and wants to get it solved'. Officers seem willing to 'go the extra mile' on these cases, working on little or no rest and pushing themselves to the limit of exhaustion. Investigator-8 said, 'when it's a 'true victim', that's when everybody busts ass . . . Yeah you get tired, been up for 24 or 48, but when it's a 'true victim' you just push through it . . . Everyone works [the case] until it gets closed, but some get closed faster than others.'

Dealing with 'true victim' cases clearly provokes a spate of emotions for detectives. For example, referring to a medical professional who was killed during a home invasion Investigator-8 recounted:

Here was a woman, for 57 years of her life she has been nothing but an outstanding citizen, a pillar of our society; a woman who made a difference. She made one mistake in her life [opening her condominium door to the offender], one mistake and it cost her her life. And I was mad because of that son of a bitch. He took somebody's life who's made a difference. I know nobody thinks one life is more important than another, that's the liberal view of it; that's bullshit. That guy right there is a piece of shit and that woman did nothing but good.

As 'true victim' cases are more emotionally taxing than cases involving an element of victim precipitation, the detectives tended to dwell on them over time. Investigator-16 talked about children-involved cases having a bigger impact on him: 'I've been on so many [homicide scenes], but obviously, there's two or three that are always at the top of your head . . . one in particular is a kid, a little seven-year-old girl that was killed and I mean killed by her own parents . . . That was a hard scene.'

The level and intensity of emotions that accompany working 'true victim' cases prompted detectives to prioritize their work. They appeared generally cynical and uninspired by cases involving at-risk victims that contributed to their own demise. This was documented by Investigator-3 who describing his current case noted, 'This one, it's dope related. I put those on the back burner and I prefer to focus on this [other] case, where my victims are innocent.'

Selectively emphasizing a lack of personal connexion to the ‘deserving’ victims seems to shield the detectives from constant emotional attachment to their cases. Investigators contended that one must conserve his/her emotions. Investigator-6 discussed this as follows:

There are some victims that I do label as innocent victims; those are the ones that are just minding their own business. They haven’t put themselves in a predicament. They for all intents and purposes [are] victims. Those one’s I kind of take personally. Then sometimes you’ve got a couple dope boys who kill each other. A lot of [detectives] go, ‘to hell with it’. Well, they still want to solve it, but it doesn’t wear on you as much as [a case involving] a kid walking down the street and somebody shoots off a round and a stray bullet goes through their head. That one you’re gonna take personal. You’re gonna take that a hell of a lot more personal . . . and I think that’s everybody up here.

Referring to the patterned nature of the cases, Investigator-6 said, ‘you see it day in and day out—what one man can do to another man, most of the time over useless . . . petty crap. That can wear on you after a while.’

We theorize that investigators use the ‘true victim’ or precipitating victim taxonomy as a keying mechanism (Goffman 1974) to decide how they will work their cases. Investigator-4 explained that although a detective’s job is to approach all homicides in the same manner, the perceived motive of the killing is used to categorize the victim and shape the investigation:

Keep in mind we work every case [hard], whether it’s an innocent person or a dope dealer that got killed doing what he does or whatever. But to kind of justify that . . . you got some guy that was selling drugs for a living or whatever and he gets robbed and killed by somebody. This drug dealer is not going to be a great loss to society.

Investigator-12 was more blunt about the role of ‘true victim’ in their case prioritization:

I’d say 70 % of our homicide victims played some part in their homicide. Whether it’s that they’re out committing a crime, or whether they’re just doing something silly that’s putting them in harm’s way, you know? But for the real victims who were just minding their business and doing what . . . they’ve been brought up to do or trying to live a decent, honest life, yeah . . . I can honestly say I do a little bit more on those particular cases. I might go above and beyond.

In precipitating victim cases, investigators seemingly struggle to fully commit to the case, in part because the offender’s motivation is evident and even perceived to be reasonable. Investigator-1 captures this cognitive dissonance well:

You look at [the victim’s criminal history report] and you see aggravated assault, sexual battery, child molestation and you’re like, ‘gee do really want to find a guy who did this?’ Or, ‘you probably did society a favour’. But you look and see what [the victim did] for a living and you’re like, ‘I gotta find this person and bring him in’. And just say, ‘look, he’s gonna come by it in court, but you know you did something wrong’. [That prioritisation became] harder when I got over here [to the homicide unit]. Because, like I said, you try not to take these cases personally, but you do.

We next theorize about how these perceptions are compartmentalized.

How are case prioritizations justified?

Clearly, the victim type elicits an emotional reaction from detectives and sets the stage for their investigative efforts that follow. These findings are consistent with the

conclusions of [Stenross and Kleinman \(1989\)](#), who suggest that strategic interactions are used to manage encounters with challenging others in order to reduce the mental and emotional work associated with investigations. Goffman's (1974) Frame Analysis provides a useful tool for organizing and understanding the way detectives justify the realities of homicide work and compartmentalize the cognitive dissonance that follows from the above-detailed victim typification. The frames, keying and tracking concepts described by Goffman are readily applicable to this inquiry.

Frames provide officers with the cues that define how work gets prioritized and ultimately done; this includes sterile tasks as well as emotion work. As noted above, [Goffman \(1974\)](#) operationalized five different types of frames that people use to compartmentalize information before they act. The main frame or track is the baseline frame that captures the dominant ideology that one uses to make sense of the social world and apply outward to specific strips of reality or subject matter. Further noted above, Goffman maintained that challenges or perceived threats to the viability of the main frame will result in 're-keying' or alterations to the main frame into four other types of ancillary frames: the directional, concealment, overlay or disattend frames. The following text seeks to operationalize these various tracks as they apply to the way that this group of homicide investigators framed the way they work their cases.

Main frame

In the main frame, detectives preserve the rhetoric of equally prioritizing and pursuing their caseload. When directly asked if detectives' prioritize their cases, a predictable main frame emerged—that victim type does not determine how the case is worked. As Investigator-5 commented, 'I don't care if the victim was a drug dealer. I don't care if the victim was anything else. He is still a victim, period. And, I have to work the case no matter what.'

This main frame allows detectives to set forth a positive image by drawing upon dominant societal values and morals. References to the family unit were a common feature to the main frame. This is exemplified by the following Investigator-13 quote:

I don't care if that person was the scum of the earth at the time; he's still someone's son, child, husband, or father. So what drives me to come here every day and put in the hours that I put in and the energy I do is to see the face of the family when, if, the jury comes back with the verdict guilty.

References to justice and retribution were also a common component of the main frame set forth by investigators. Investigators routinely espoused that the intentional killing of another should yield a certain and severe punishment for the offender. In short, it is a homicide detective's core responsibility to bring each and every killer to justice. Hence, Investigator-24 noted, 'you gotta be kind of clinical about things cause this is your job . . . you gotta put all the killers in jail'. In the back of the detective's mind, the worst case scenario results when an officer misses the opportunity to solve a case involving a non-ideal victim only to see the offender remain at large and cause the demise of an ideal victim such as a law enforcement officer or defenceless little old lady. Using both of the above themes, Investigator-26 said 'your underlying root cause for wanting to work the case is either for the family or you want to put the offender in jail'.

Generally, detectives invoked the standard 'all cases are worked the same' theme when presenting the main frame on the investigative process. However, when the conversation shifted to individual cases, laminates were invoked to justify victim typification.

To protect the master definition of the detective, ancillary frames are used to justify specific victim prioritizations.

Directional frame

In the directional frame, detectives acknowledge the totality of the situation but privilege certain points over others; emotions are a common target in this regard. As Investigator-2 said, ‘you’ve got to be objective about it . . . We can’t put our feelings into it.’ The detectives routinely acknowledged the strain associated with certain type of cases, but contended that it can be sequestered in order to work the case objectively. Investigator-3 explained:

If it’s a child crime scene . . . you have to focus on setting that emotion aside and focus on what it is you need to do . . . It’s funny, because now I automatically just push [emotions] out and I look at the body and the crime scene just strictly as a case or evidence. But again, it is kind of difficult with children. But I know that if you tear up on a [crime] scene or you get emotional you’re not going to be effective. And that’s what drives me to push back the emotion and hold it in.

Victim classifications are another facet of the homicide investigation that are perceived but routinely downplayed via directional tracking. Investigator-23 admits to using victim classifications, but stresses that the need to close the case must take precedent:

I am going to work the case as hard as I can no matter who the victim was, what their criminal history was, no matter if they were doing dope, deal, robbery, whatever. I am still going to work the case as hard as I can to try to close it. But when you have to look at a mother and tell her that her sixteen year old was walking down the sidewalk and got hit by a stray bullet, it takes a little bit more out of you than going and telling a mom that knows that her son deals dope and she knew the reality that this day was coming.

This quote captures the sense that the emotional strain of working a ‘true victim’ case is different than with a precipitating victim, nevertheless this detective disregards that fact whilst preserving an underlying commitment and unbiased orientation towards cases.

When reality conflicts with the main frame, the directional frame is predictably employed to acknowledge but divert scepticism. Below, Investigator-17 repeatedly returns to case closure as a factor that can overcome all else:

There are some cases that you . . . think, “well if this wouldn’t get solved then we really won’t cry about it; we really won’t be upset about it.” But I think most people; I know I do . . . want to solve all your cases. But how motivated are you gonna be if you have one of those [dope boy] cases? I mean I don’t look at any case like I don’t care if this thing gets solved or not. I mean, I think most people would want to solve all their cases, but there’ll be some where you are just like, ‘you know, you can take your time on it or nobody’s gonna be ruffling your feathers about it because it’s not gonna be a high priority . . . it is a drug boy on drug boy, so who cares?’

Many of the investigators pointed out the difference between ‘true victims’ and precipitating victims whilst framing how they do not take it personal or let it affect their work product.

Concealment frame

In the concealment frame, there is an effort to completely hide certain details or realities from the outside world despite their clear relevance. Detectives often use this frame

by blaming others to absolve themselves of responsibility in case outcomes. The command staff or news media's treatment of high profile cases is fitting in this regard. It is well established that the media is prone to provide sustained coverage and even sensationalize cases involving 'true victims' (Beckett and Sasson 2004). Detectives and command staff members are clearly sensitive to media attention and thus place an emphasis on quickly resolving those cases that draw and sustain media attention. By emphasizing the role that the media plays in elevating or lowering the public profile of a case, detectives can downplay their own role in setting a case's perceived priority. The following quote from Investigator-10 provides an example of a detective concealing his position towards cases whilst pointing to the reason why some cases are prioritized over others—the media, administration and the public, not themselves:

For me it's all the same, but it's not about just me. With the media, the [police department] administration and the public, the outcry is different for these [non-ideal or true] victims. Nobody gives a fuck about poor [adult] people dying. I don't care what their race is. Nobody gives a fuck. Poor babies, poor infants, yes. That's different . . . But I can't get caught up in that bullshit. I'm gonna work the dope boy case . . . the dope boy that has the crack in his hand and the gun in his hand . . . I'm gonna work [it] the same way I work that baby case. And that's just how it is. Now, who drives the bus? Well, public and the media, they drive the bus, because they put out there what they want. What's sensational and what's gonna drive ratings, drive tears, whatever? So it gets confused. And see the public thinks we only give a fuck about the cases . . . that involve the rich white people and shit like that.

Detectives routinely concealed their role in case prioritization by pointing to the difference in organizational commitment. Investigator-7 concealed his/her orientation to 'true victims' by justifying case prioritization as a product of unit-level teamwork:

I think personally that's true . . . But as far as collectively [working hard], when the ['true victim'] doctor died, we were all like, 'What can I do? What can I do?' You give me a drug dealer that's killed, I'm gonna work it as hard as I can. But there ain't gonna be five guys standing at my desk asking, 'What do you need me to do?' You know, but for the [murdered] doctor, I mean we had everybody asking, even people outside of Homicide, 'What can we do to help?' That's cause, you know, that's a 'true victim.'

Whilst using the concealment frame to deflect responsibility for prioritizing cases is useful in maintaining their self-image, detectives also use it to describe how they stay focused on the task at hand. This is evident in the following quote of Investigator-5:

I mean it's horrible and it's ugly, especially when you go to the hospital and the kids got, you know, injuries that are a month old . . . a fractured rib, fractured leg and he's three months old. Yeah, you're fucking pissed off; you can't believe somebody [did this]. But you got to go into that interview room and be a cool customer and really try to get these people to talk to you . . . You can't go in there fucking angry, wanting to punch the guy in the fucking face. You gotta go in there and be like, 'oh, hey, man.' Your goal is to close that case; to get that confession. Whatever you gotta be . . . tactics change depending on the situation. But [when you] go into that interview, it should be your plan, not your emotion, leading you. If you're going to go in there and be tough and be hard or whatever, that's fine, but make that decision based on this is the best way to go forward with the case. Not just because my emotions are telling me to do that. You gotta take that out of it.

Although they took on several different manifestations, the interviews revealed the repeated use of concealment frames designed to cover up or dismiss the emotional

aspects of homicide cases. These concealment efforts were most pronounced when the emotions were raw and the viability of the main storey, the ‘we work all cases the same’ storey, was in jeopardy.

Overlay frame

In the overlay frame, some information is routinized so investigators can seem as though they work in an impersonal and methodical manner regardless of the circumstances. This allows for a reassured sense of self and competence. Detectives seemed to use the overlay frame to simplify the task at hand. Indeed, Investigator-6 said:

That’s what they say up here [in homicide], ‘just keep it old school, don’t try to reinvent the wheel.’ Some guys will even go so far as saying, ‘hey, you know, it’s only murder, don’t make it more than it is.’ Its basic police work, basic police investigation work. Don’t get caught up in murder, its homicide. Don’t get caught up in that. Keep it simple; it’s just a murder.

Echoing the idea that a routine is developed in homicide work, Investigator-18 explained:

It’s just like being on patrol; you get to where you do certain things a certain way. You have a routine that you go by because you’ve learnt that that’s the best way to do it or that’s the safest way to do it. And it’s the same thing here. You know, I will eventually develop a routine where I will show up on the call and I’ll have a routine down pat . . . this is what I’m going to do, because this is the best way get me to the end game.

Simplification allows detectives to depersonalize aspects of emotionally charged cases. To this point, Investigator-4 talked about using humour to mechanize cases:

We’re looking at the worst side of man . . . You see what’s been done to these [victims]. You try to keep it from being a personal thing and I think that has a lot to do with why we can go on these horrific scenes and we can joke and talk about things that would just absolutely appal other people. So you try to keep it in its place. Even though I’m looking at this horrible thing, I’ve got a job to do. I’ve got to do this and that and the other thing and you try to keep it like that.

Other detectives invoked an overlay frame that stressed a need to ‘not get caught-up’ in the depressing and imperfect nature of homicide work. Investigator-10 captured this point well:

You can’t get too caught up in [cases that go unsolved] because you know sometimes it’s justifiable; you’re victim was a fucked up person and they did some bad shit. And because you worked it hard you showed that was their fault they’re dead . . . There are very few innocent victims of murder. Most of people put themselves in a position to get killed.

By invoking overlay tracks that stress the simplistic and routinized aspects of homicide work, detectives were able to further deflect attention from the case prioritization that existed at the individual and unit level.

Disattend frame

Persons enlist a disattend track when seeking to alter the perceived reality of a given situation or storyline. Given the emotionally charged and high-pressure nature of homicide work, it should not be surprising that detectives are tempted to fabricate or misrepresent parts of an investigation to control the message. As elsewhere, this exercise is

usually linked to case prioritization. A common application in this regard focused on how heavy caseloads force tough decisions on which cases get the most attention. Asked about an open case, Investigator-3 responded:

I'm not using an excuse, but when I got that particular case, it was at a time when [I was] bombarded with other cases. And when you're bombarded with a lot of cases, you prioritise and you move the cases you can solve quicker and then sometimes you continuously get bombarded with one case after the other and then years go by before you could ever go back to something.

Investigators also routinely excuse open cases by pointing to a lack of viable leads. As Investigator-15 noted:

[This case] is one of these we call 'bag of shit's' that you get the day after Thanksgiving, the Friday after Thanksgiving at four o'clock in the morning. You know, they respond to a shooting up on [street name] by the [business reference] and this homeless guy is laying out there with gunshot and he's dead. No shell casings, no witnesses, nothing. I didn't even know who he was for several hours. So I mean that, you, that laid on your desk what do you get, what do you do? So you got to start on that one at some point, but there really isn't anything, nobody has come forward to say that they were, you know, the victim's mother is old, I mean she's in her 70's or whatever and you know she doesn't know any of her son's friends because he's homeless and you know . . . So some cases just have no angle.

In such instances, follow-up questioning often revealed that the investigator had yet to explore common evidence collection exercises. This could include pulling phone records, processing physical evidence or interviewing family members.

There was also recurring evidence of disattend track manifestations with detectives attributing inefficiencies and a lack of results to others. Detectives often accounted for unsolved cases by pointing to deficiencies in crime scene processing. For example, it was also common for an investigator to criticize the crime scene technicians as incompetent and lazy, such as Investigator-2 who said 'one of our biggest hindrances is the crime scene [unit]'. Here, disattend tracking manifests itself as excuses or justifications that downplayed personal responsibility whilst emphasizing the role of officials from other divisions of the police department (e.g. patrol, crime scene investigation) outside organizations (e.g. medical examiner, district attorney's office), the media or citizen onlookers. Indeed, investigators discussed the stress provoked by all of the people at a crime scene as a distraction to being able to do their job. As was the case with disattend tracking focused on media or caseload-based pressures, follow-up questions often revealed sketchy legitimacy to the claims.

Discussion

This inquiry describes how members of a metropolitan police department's homicide unit construct reality regarding types of victims and case prioritization. We use Goffman's (1974) frame analysis to illustrate the use of certain culturally based storylines and tracks that aid investigators in managing the emotions that go along with this taxing form of police work. When orienting to the victims of homicide, investigators differentiated between 'true victims' who died largely at no fault of their own and more deserving or predictable victims who put themselves at risk of violence due to their life choices. For the investigators in this sample, victimology defines how they

orient to their work. The typification of a 'true victim' was predictably invoked for certain types of people (e.g. children, the elderly, fellow police officers) or for those killed whilst pursuing honest and upstanding lives. Conversely, the typification of a precipitating victim was imposed upon those who provoked the violence, were immersed in a criminal lifestyle (e.g. 'dope boys' and gang members), were members of at-risk demographic groups or put themselves in harm's way. There was a patterned nature to the background and foreground factors that shaped these typifications. Individual investigators, as well as collective sentiments of the unit, suggest that 'true victim' cases, whilst rare, are prioritized over the latter, which account for the majority of cases they are assigned. 'True victim' cases also evoked greater emotion and cognitive dissonance for the investigators than did the garden variety murder cases.

Goffman's (1974) frame analysis serves as a valuable heuristic tool to organize the actions and storytelling of the behaviours and actions of the investigators under study. We find evidence of a main frame serving to compartmentalize conflicting or overwhelming realities of homicide work. Detectives used framing tracks and re-keying to adapt to a multitude of situations. By organizing their frames to fit the circumstances, they manage the emotional strain of working cases. This strain comes from many sources such as police administrators, the media, uncooperative witnesses and suspects, victim and suspect families, onlookers, the media and support staff. Interview conversations suggested that although dead men do not tell tales (or interact with the investigators), the perception of the background, lifestyle and final actions of the homicide victim weighs heavily on the detectives that seek to bring closure to their deaths. In short, it appears that detectives internalize the stress associated with 'true victim' cases, whilst they deflect the stress that presents itself in garden variety cases. The internalized stress drives the individuals and collective to work long and hard to solve the case. Concomitantly, the deflected stress seems to reduce the urgency and commitment that the homicide unit members bring to their investigative efforts. Case prioritization thus manifests itself in a series of patterned stories and tracks that allow order to be imposed in a very taxing work environment.

Implications

Several theoretical insights follow from this inquiry. First, we hope this project will re-stimulate interest in Goffman's frame analysis as a heuristic device within the realm of sociology of crime and deviance. This subject matter was the primary lens through which he formulated his theoretical propositions and methodological proposals. Widely considered Goffman's most ambitious single theory, *Frame Analysis* (1974) remains amongst his least utilized works within his home discipline (Manning 1980; Smith 2006). Researchers in tangential fields such as political science, communication and education have enlisted tenets of frame analysis. To our knowledge, this is the first study since Levi's work in 1981 that seeks to apply Goffman's frame analysis to a crime-related topic. We find a framing lens to be useful for organizing the way that individual investigators and the unit collective seek to make sense of various aspects of homicide work. Given the high level of scrutiny and normative assessment imposed upon police work, we submit that frame analysis provides a fruitful heuristic tool for the policing scholar. Furthermore, criminal justice scholars have been frequently criticized for their

lack of theoretical-driven research (Duffee and Maguire 2007; Cooper and Worrall 2012). Although the localized nature of criminal justice organizations and operations that follow from the decentralized nature of the justice system in America make for significant variations in the structure and processes under study, a heuristic device such as frame analysis shows promise to theorize these local cultures and reality generating efforts and thus inform our understanding.

Having undertaken one such project, we make the following theoretical observations. Although chaotic and unpredictable to the outside observer, the aftermath of a homicide is marked by a discernible structure and process. Investigators impose cognitive and behavioural routines onto the work they undertake to produce a stable set of work roles and occupational identities. They react to the stress and emotion of death investigation in patterned ways that both internalize and externalize the stress of the job. Shared meanings are discernible in their storytelling efforts.

The field work and interviews suggested that the definitions of victim types and the corresponding framing efforts are shaped by many sources. We are unable to draw definitive conclusions in this regard because the interview content did not thoroughly explore all possible sources of the perceptions and storytelling. That said, we theorize that officers' upbringing play an important part in the tendency to focus on certain background and foreground factors as they assign meaning to victim precipitation; race, age and lifestyle stereotypes are powerful and omnipresent influences in this regard. Further, we theorize that organizational norms, especially those at the unit level, play an important part in the typification process and outcomes. External factors, such as media portrayals, and the language and meanings used by news reporters and other popular culture resources also seem to influence the detectives' perceptions and behaviours.

Although the design and approach of the present study do not lend themselves to direct policy implications, this project does raise important food for thought regarding future research and policy directions. Improvements to homicide investigations would be significant in developing the function of the police. Subjective discretion, particularly based on victims' characteristics, introduces the potential for erroneous case outcomes. We noted at the outset that prior research posits a connexion between the manner in which cases are defined by detectives, how they are worked and if they are solved (Innes 2003). Our findings begin to operationalize the dynamics that underlie detective perceptions and behaviours specific to their caseloads. Assessments of victim deservedness appear to guide the reality construction efforts from the start of a case assignment and serve to shape the individual and collective investigative efforts that follow. Pressed to manage the demands of death work, investigators appear to allow victimology to yield a sense of case prioritization. It stands to reason that these normative trajectories impact case outcomes, with 'true victim' cases producing higher likelihoods of resolution through arrest relative to cases involving victims deemed to be culpable or contributing in some way to their own demise. The more we know about how homicide cases are worked, the better our practices can be designed to train and manage homicide investigators in equal effectiveness.

More generally, it is important to note that the current findings have implication that span well beyond homicide work in American police departments. First, investigation work is similar in police agencies in most nations. Although organizational culture will yield differences in the content of various frames across departments and geography, the

general observations noted here should serve as a good conceptual departure point for understanding. Second, the framing schemes outlined above are also likely applicable to other types of police work, a point that should be explored in future research. Third, much of the framing discussed above focused on the role of social factors such as the age, race and social class of the victim. These are broad social issues that have major implications for how the police, and other government agents, interact with the public they serve.

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